Prologue

The infant fell from the surface, and landed upon the desolate and ruined ground of Scyphozia. Possessing no thought and no awareness of its surroundings, the baby wailed and wailed, deep into the endless void it was surrounded by.

One day, in a stronghold that would one day become the famed Castle Light, the baby was found directly across the barrier that protected the stronghold from the horrors of Scyphozia. Incredulous and shocked at the sight, the baby was brought into the stronghold. But each and every person within that base had but one question; who was this child? How did they survive in such a horrific and desolate environment, filled with endless terrors and untold monsters? Who had brought the child here, alive and unscathed?

None could give a definitive answer, and none knew the origin of the child, who their parents could possibly be. And before any of that could even begin to be solved, the Divers themselves had to answer one question before all others: how did an infant wind up in Scyphozia, its body and soul completely intact?

Chapter 1: Opportunity

I awoke to the sound of violent crashing and thuds that echoed throughout the entirety of Castle Light; what the hell was that?

Scrambling out of bed, I pull on my Divers Apprentice Robes, and quickly file out into the main hall. I wasn't the only one confused, by the looks of it; the main hall was filled with my peers, most of them groggy and confused.

Something was up, that much was obvious. I'm about to go and ask a peer exactly what was going on, when:

"May I have everyone's attention!" A female voice pierces through the crowd.

All heads in the room turn towards the voice, as if in a trance. I squint my eyes, trying my best to make out the figure; blonde hair, a halo…

Oh, Gods below. It's Klaris. It's Klaris Llfiend, the famed Mother of Lights.

"Calm down, you ingrates. A stray Thresher wandered away from its group and winded up at the entrance of Castle Light. The situation is being handled; now go back to bed!"

Sighs of relief and exchanged looks of nervous smiles ripple throughout the crowd. The crowd breaks apart, friends finding friends and heading back to the barracks. But, this feeling…

I'm not an idiot; I'm no slouch when it comes to my studies. I've combed through the entirety of the library in Castle Light, and have read every book in there 10 times over. Everything from the famed Archivist Journals that detailed the experiments conducted on the Megalodaunt, to the hypnotizing *O Pardoner of Mine*. And my gut is telling me there is no way in *hell* that a single Thresher could've possibly been the reason for all that noise.

Could it have been an Owl, rare as they are? No, they are quiet in their assaults, the only sound they make being their loud, thumping footsteps. A King Gigamed? No, they only shock and spawn children to attack threats…

My eyes glaze over and drift throughout the room; I'm racing through every possibility, every last possible conclusion that could make sense. I don't notice the footsteps approaching me.

"Oi, you there. The Capra."

My eyes lurch up, and my stomach simultaneously seizes up. Klaris is staring right at me; there is no room for hoping that it could be someone behind me.

"Come up here, now."

I've heard the term "walking the plank", but I never knew I would be doing it myself one day; or, at least that's what it felt like walking up to Klaris. Every step felt like it took an eternity, every intake of breath a millenia. Eventually, I reached her.

"I've been watching your progress for a while now, Capra. You may have deluded your peers into thinking you are nothing but a bookworm, but I know better."

I'm stunned into silence, my heart racing. What could she mean; is she insane? All I've ever done is read and train with the others as per usual…

"I've been promoted to the head of the expeditions into the Second Layer. I'll have my hands full, and won't have the time to deal with other issues plaguing Castle Light. That's where you come in." Klaris' tone is that of haughtiness and pride.

I remain silent, not daring to speak out of turn.

"It is your job to keep your eyes open and ears out for any, ah, *rumors* that may come and go from this point forward. Anything that sounds suspicious, you report directly to me."

Unable to stop myself, I ask:

"Why?"

Klaris' brow furrows.

"What, are you fishing for compliments? You are easily one of the most analytical and sharp students of your class; you've eclipsed your peers in nearly every category."

"I won't dispute that, but again; why? What is the purpose of relaying baseless rumors to you?" I ask, incredulous.

"I can't answer that." Klaris surprisingly averts her eyes.

I'm frustrated. If I'm gonna be some kind of *spy*, I better know why.

"Forgive me, Klaris, but I refuse. I won't be a messenger for no reason, without any benefit." I turn to walk away.

I'm not even 3 steps away from Klaris when her voice pierces out:

"How about becoming a Black Diver?"

Chapter 2: Vision

I tense up as if shot, taking a moment to comprehend the words Klaris just uttered. Slowly, I turn around.

"A Black Diver?" I sound the words out, slowly pronouncing each syllable.

Klaris nods, annoyance flashing on her face.

A million thoughts race through my head; the Black Diver certificate hanging on my wall, the outfit hanging in my closet, the oo's and ahh's I would receive from others as they saw me wear the esteemed coat of the Black Diver's.

"I accept." No hesitation, no second thoughts. Becoming a Black Diver...a dream every Divers Apprentice held, just handed to me on a silver platter. Oh, how I dreamed of days like this!

"I knew you'd come around." A devilish grin spreads across Klaris' face.

"Yeah, well, I'd be stupid not to take that offer." Anyone would be.

"You begin tomorrow. Remain inconspicuous and unsuspicious. Don't let anyone find out what you are doing." Klaris crosses her arms.

Fueled by excitement, I salute and exit the room, heading to bed.

~~

I wake up, unable to move, unable to blink. Darkness surrounds me, my vision seeing nothing but pitch black. Fear shoots through me, and I try relentlessly to escape, to move, to *breathe*.

My eyes adjust to the darkness, to my surroundings. It's then that I realize that I am not in Castle Light; I am not in my bed. My eyes dart around the area, trying to identify anything that would unveil my location. And then I see it.

Where there was once nothing in front of me now stands a horribly disfigured stone statue. Coral grows at its base, moss growing out of every crevice and crack. My eyes slowly trail upward; I know what's coming. Deep down, I recognize this, this *statue*. I know what I'm about to see. And yet, that knowledge does nothing to stem my fear. I finally peer at the statue in full, and my heart stops.

Eyes, soulless eyes peer right back at me. They are unblinking, and they do not stop staring at me. I'm shadowed in terror, bathed in it, drowning in its inescapable frost. Dimly, I get the sense that whatever this thing is, it gazes beyond me. I get the feeling that it looks into my soul.

I try to speak, try to make any sound I can, but I am still bound by invisible strings. I'm helpless, left at the whim of this statue. And it's when that realization hits again that the statue speaks:

"~~Your name, forgotten. A vessel, for your uses. A blank slate, an animal led by it's master.~~"

The words are grating; they are *wrong*. Every fiber of my being shudders in agony as the words fill my head. There is no voice, no *life* in this thing.

"~~And yet, even the most dim of masters give their dogs a name. Rejoice, o' fallen one, you will be given the privilege of an identity.~~"

The pain spikes tenfold, darkness clouding my vision. I can't concentrate, can't focus on whatever this *thing* is saying. I finally, *finally* blink and…

I'm staring at the ceiling. I shoot upwards, looking around; I'm back in Castle Light, back home. And yet, the fear doesn't leave me. The feeling of comfort I once had in this safe haven is gone. Because two words sit on my lips, waiting to be uttered, waiting to be brought into existence. A name, an identity.

"Arthur Mirad."

Chapter 3: Prophet

I toil with the name internally, goosebumps rocketing throughout my body. Absent-mindedly, I get out my uniform and begin my day, lost in thought. Fear of the likes of which I have never

experienced before blankets all my senses; I can't even pretend that I'm all the way there, that I'm hearing the words of my instructors, that I'm paying attention to anything trying to grasp it.

I never saw it fit to mention before, but I've never had a name. I remember asking as a child why I never had or received one, but they swiftly changed the subject, being so obvious in doing so that I never brought it up again. As far as I know, I was never named by my parents, whoever they might've been. Castle Light is all I've ever known, all I've ever experienced. No doubt that me being nameless served to strengthen me being shunned by my peers. I have no memories, had no connection to anything outside of Castle Light; until now.

As I struggle comprehending my very humanity, I remember with a shock that I should've been, ah, *spying* for Klaris. Choosing to let the "dream" I had sit on the back burner for now, I focus my attention back into reality. I scope my surroundings, and the people conversing around me. Nothing seems to be off. All seems to be well.

Until, out of the corner of my eye, I spotted the shadow of…*someone* creeping into a room, and quietly shut the door behind them, doing it so slowly that it instantly struck me as suspicious. I suddenly stand up, alarming those within my immediate vicinity. Shooting them an apologetic smile, I quickly turn around and head for the door, attempting to be as discreet as I possibly can. Reaching the door, illuminated by dim lights without a soul around, I press my ear against the door and begin to listen for a hint of whatever this person may be doing.

An odd humming emanates from the door, causing my bones to tremble. I gaze downward, and my stomach lurches when I notice a faint red glow pass through the bottom of the door. And then a voice from within the room begins to speak:

"All is well, Prophet. The expedition begins tomorrow, and I command the helm. Our vision will be realized, our aspirations fulfilled."

A disembodied voice replies, being muffled to the point I can't decipher any real vocal tone.

"No, Prophet. Nobody suspects a thing; I've played my part well, just as you've ordered me to. Using the power you've granted me, I will explore the Second Layer and relay any vital information that will aid in our endeavors."

My heart stops. Whoever this person is…they are the leader of the expedition into the Second Layer. And they are, or rather, *have*

been, betraying us to some sort of “Prophet”, relaying information to them. The question is, what information has been given?

I stumble backward, a cold sweat taking over my senses. As quietly as I can, I leave, fearing what would happen lest I be caught. I need to find Klaris, *now*. We’ve been breached.

Chapter 4: Barrierless

As covertly as possible, I sprint throughout Castle Light, frantically checking room after room in search of Klaris. As the number of rooms dwindle down more and more, the panic begins to set in. Just where the hell is Klaris?

Just as I burst into the last room in the compound, a distant rumbling echoes throughout Castle Light. Sirens wail overheard, the lights flickering overhead and a robotic voice speaks crackles over the intercom.

“WARNING, WARNING. A GROUP OF MONSTER’S HAVE DESTROYED THE BARRIER. SEEK IMMEDIATE SHELTER. WARNING, WARNING. A GROUP OF MONSTER’S HAVE DESTROYED THE BARRIER. SEEK IMMEDIATE SHELTER.”

I jolted; another monster attack, in such a short span of time? Frustration wells up inside of me. Just how am I supposed to find Klaris in all this mess? I turn around and begin sprinting back to the dorms, weaving through crowds of panicked Apprentices. It’s not easy navigating Castle Light with the lights flickering on and off constantly, but I manage to find my dorm room. Pushing through the door, I head to the window overlooking the bridge between Castle Light and beyond. And my heart drops.

Plumes of smoke and debris are sent in all directions; it’s utter chaos. In the distance, I can barely make out weaponized Song sent into the eternal darkness; amber flame, emerald green, yellow thunder. Muffled roars and screams pierce the walls of Castle Light; only a fool would assume things were going well down there. I can’t tear my eyes away from the carnage unfolding before my very eyes; I’m transfixed.

That is, until someone clad in the Black Diver uniform jumps into the fray, and single handedly ends the threat. A massive flash of light, a thunderous boom, and it’s all over . In no less than 20 seconds, what was once an army of monsters is no more. The sudden silence is eerie; without realizing, I breathe out the breath I’ve been holding. I try to discern the heroic figure beyond the plumes of dust, but just can’t manage to do so. Throwing caution to the wind, I decide to head down and take a look, up close and personal. Consequences be damned, I need to see who did this.

I quickly head downstairs, my mind reeling from what I’ve just seen. Just who could’ve been so powerful as to reduce an army of monsters to ash? I reach the gate, and look beyond to our savior.

The figure stands with his back to the compound, seemingly in a trance. His white, unkempt hair sticks out in multiple directions, his earrings polished and glowing. A sword is strapped to his back, somehow *floating*. I stare and stare, unable to tear my eyes away. Unconsciously, I recognized the figure in front of me by his description. A somewhat new recruit, someone with unparalleled talent and strength, someone who's broken numerous records and risen up the ranks of the Divers in the shortest time on record.

The dual-attuned Katana wielding Black Diver, Akira.

Chapter 5: Expedition

My mouth agape, I continue to gawk at Akira, unable to fully comprehend what I'm seeing. A legend in the flesh, a mythical figure standing right before my very eyes. Catching myself, I shut my mouth and begin to approach him, a jolt of fear echoing throughout my body. I'm within 3 paces of him when I notice an instrument of some sort resting at his hip; the…*bell* is a deep purple, stuck to his hip as if glued there.

Only a foolish Apprentice wouldn't have heard of the rumors concerning Akira, specifically his bell. Although not confirmed by any of the higher-ups of the Divers, it's rumored Akira's bell can, ah, *pop* your head. And while that should've deterred me from approaching him any further and risking incurring his wrath, I shove those concerns down and walk the rest of the way to Akira, sticking an arm out.

As if sensing my presence, Akira turns, gazing upon me. His eyes narrow upon seeing my hand outstretched for a handshake, and he looks me up and down, seemingly in contempt. I give him a nervous smile, trying to be as cordial as possible. With a sigh of annoyance, Akira extends his arm and shakes my hand. Internally, I breathe a sigh of relief.

"Who are you?" Akira's voice is laced with suspicion.

I snap back into reality, focusing back into the conversation at hand.

"Arthur Mirad, sir." I can't bury the fear in my tone, but I have questions that desperately need answers.

"Arthur Mirad…I've never heard of you before. Are you a new recruit?" His eyebrows raise as he seemingly runs through his memories.

"No, sir. I've only recently chosen a name for myself. I was raised in Castle Light, being primed for a Diver all my life. Whereas, you joined after being scouted for your talent." Shoot; I'd come off as contemptuous.

"That would explain it. Now, Arthur; why have you approached me? What do you want?" His tone is scathing; I guess I've ticked him off.

"Akira, sir, forgive me; I must inquire over Klaris' whetherbouts. I have important information to give to her, and it cannot wait."

"I don't know where Klaris is, and I don't see why she would want to discuss information with an Apprentice like *you*." Hostility lines his tone,

his eyes flashing purple, his nostrils flaring. Every cell in my body is screaming at me to run, but I shove the urge down; I have to see Klaris and pass along that a traitor is within our midst.

"Akira, sir, please. Do you have any idea where she could be?" I come off as pleading, but if pleading will get the job done then so be it.

"Last I heard, she should be in the last room of the compound sending down the first group into the Second Layer." He breathes a heavy sigh and rolls his eyes.

"Thank you! I really appreciate this." I excitedly grin at him and sprint back into the compound, not giving him a chance to respond. I weave through the rooms, sprinting past guards yelling at me to slow down and stop. As I see Klaris in the distance alongside other Apprentices, a bright light envelops the room in which she resides. A musical tone sounds out, the light getting ever brighter. And then… it stops. The light fades, the musical tone fading along with it. I'm too late. The first group into the Second Layer has been sent down.

Chapter 6: Doubts

Instantly, I begin to panic. I reach the room, rushing at Klaris, throwing all my cordial and respectful tendencies aside for the moment and grabbing her shoulders roughly.

"Klaris; is there any way you can bring the Divers you just sent down back up?" I'm panicking; but I may be able to remedy my mistake if Klaris brings them back.

Klaris glares at me and shoves my arms off of her shoulders, clearly disgusted. Brushing off her shoulders, she grabs my forearm roughly and drags me into a neighboring room. It seems she wants some privacy. After shutting the door softly and locking it, she turns to me and folds her arms, clearly waiting for me to begin explaining myself. I gulp, and begin.

"Klaris; those Divers that you sent down just now are in serious danger. The leader of the expedition, I don't know who, is in cahoots with some sort of *Prophet*, whoever that is. I heard him talking with whomever that Prophet was in secret."

Klaris, who until up to this point has been tapping her index finger on her arm impatiently, suddenly tenses up as if shot. She searches my eyes for any sort of deception, but of course there isn't any. How could I fabricate a story as extreme as this? After staring me down for an awkwardly long amount of time, she sighs and unfolds her arms, putting her face into her hands and groaning out of annoyance.

"Listen, Capra. I'll give you one chance to take back what you've said, and admit that all of it was a lie. I'll even do you a favor and not throttle you for lying to my face." Feigned laughter lines her tone. I could very well be risking my future as a Black Diver (and my life) if I kept speaking. But

my pride won't allow me to pretend that I made this story up. Because I'm not lying.

"Klaris, none of what I just told you, not a single word, was fabricated. I didn't make it up for jokes, for giggles, for laughs. Everything I conveyed to you just now is exactly what happened, word for word." I get a little angered that Klaris would think I would make any of this up.

Slowly, Klaris peers up at me. I stare right back, rigid in posture. And as if exhausted, Klaris slumps down into a nearby chair, rubbing her temples. Confused, I remain standing, trying to understand just *what* would have Klaris this…*defeated*. Even the weird halo thing floating above her head has dimmed in brightness. With a heavy sigh, she begins to speak:

"Capra, what you've uncovered goes beyond your understanding. If what you say is true, we may potentially have the Ministry on our backs, and the 9 Prophets as a result. The leader of the expedition you mentioned; Chaser. Are you sure he's the one you heard speaking with the Prophet?" She interlocks her fingers and seems to be deep in thought.

I nod. There is no doubt in my mind that Chaser was the one speaking with the Prophet.

Klaris sighs, and opens the door to our room, clearly intending to leave. But before she walks through the door, she gives me one more glance, and speaks:

"As of right now, I cannot forcefully pull the expedition team out of the Second Layer without any good reason. If I spouted off ramblings of Prophets and Chaser's betrayal without any substantial evidence, my position and reputation would be put into jeopardy. It goes without saying that this conversation stays between the both of us."

I nod.

"I'll begin preparations with the other Black Divers in case of a siege on our stronghold, and possibly on the entire Diver faction as a whole. This information is life-saving, Capra. You have my thanks." She gives me a small smile and leaves the room, softly shutting the door behind her.

I burst with excitement, leaping into the air; surely, *surely* this information would have boosted my chances of becoming a Black Diver, right? I leave the room and head back to my barracks, my head in the clouds. Day by day, my dreams are getting closer and closer to becoming a reality.

Chapter 7: Trials

You'd think with all of the risks suddenly presented at our doorstep, Castle Light would've gone into lockdown and began preparations for the invasion of an enemy faction. Logically, that'd be the correct move, right? Apparently not.

The day was going as per usual, nothing seeming to be out of the ordinary. I wake up and go about my routine; get out of bed, shower, brush my teeth, all of that. I head to the mess hall to procure my breakfast (if nine slices of french toast could even be called that), when the doors to the mess hall all of a sudden slam shut; all of them, all at once.

Obviously, this got the attention of us Apprentices. Some got up and attempted to open the doors back up, to no avail. Murmuring began in droves, people inquiring over why we were locked inside; and I was no different. For all I knew, we were trapped in here. Just as everyone began to panic slightly, an unfamiliar voice came on over the intercom.

"*PZZT*...*PZZT*...is this thing on?" A gruff voice grumbles, clearly annoyed.

"Give it here, you buffoon." Loud feedback from the microphone rings out, causing everyone to cover their ears in pain.

"You know I'm not up to date with all of this...technology." The gruff voice, seemingly male, rings out, now clear enough to distinguish from the crackling static.

"You know they can hear you, right?" A distinctly shrewd female voice sounds out, assumingly the woman calling the other a 'buffoon'.

"So? It's not like they'll give a-" The gruff voice is cut off.

The shrewd female voice returns, finally addressing the crowd of hundreds of Diver Apprentices staring up at the loudspeaker lodged in the ceiling.

"Hello, all of you apprentices! My name is Faye. My buddy over here's named Reg. You all must be so confused; for what reason are we speaking to you, and so early at that? Well..."

She trails off, seemingly trying to build up tension. I can already visualize her doing invisible drums.

"We are excited to announce to you all, what is to be the first ever *Citadel Trials!*" Faye makes a makeshift explosion and crowd cheering noises, trying to build up excitement, I presume. Nobody's excited though; we *did* just wake up after all. However, what Faye says next changes that.

"The Citadel Trials are an elaborate bout of challenges for you Apprentices; they'll challenge you in all aspects of your body, mind and spirit. Don't take this lightly, folks; you'll be bloody and beaten if you underestimate just how far we are willing to push you all."

"The first challenge; you will venture out into the Wastes and kill a monster; that's not all, however. You must bring back evidence of your kill, lest we assume you cheated and took something from the potions room."

"The second challenge; mental clarity. You will be put into precarious situations, that we won't spoil just yet. You will be graded on how well you can operate under fire."

"The third, and final challenge. If you've made it this far, you'll have a one month grace period after the second challenge to learn under a mentor of your choice residing here within Castle Light, Reg and I included. Why, you may ask? Oh, no reason...it's just that the final

challenge will consist of an elaborate tournament of the remaining Apprentices! You will each be graded based on combat skill and intellect, and just how far you are willing to go to win in battle. Be warned, though; it's only one person to a mentor, so be quick in choosing who you want teaching you! And..that's that-"

The gruff male voice from before chimes in; Reg. He cuts Faye off.

"And the prize for the winning Apprentice in the end of *all* of this...is the opportunity to gain a *Resonance*."

I freeze mid-bite, my eyes going as wide as saucers. I slowly look around the mess hall, gazing at each and every face here. My peers; no, *competition* is doing the exact same. Reg is continuing to speak, but I don't hear him; the mood, the very air in this room has shifted. I shovel down my french toast, slowly chewing as I study the competition surrounding me, making a mental note of every potential foe. There's no playing around, not when it comes to something like this.

I'm getting that damned Resonance, no matter the cost.

Chapter 8: Carcass

I begin my preparations for the Citadel Trials; it's not enough to be prepared for the first alone. If I'm going to secure my victory, I have to put in hours of work and be a million steps ahead of all my peers. I set up a concise schedule that I'll be following until the trials begin; according to Faye, we'll have a two month grace period before the trials themselves begin, which is just enough time for me to complete my checklist.

First off; research. More specifically, research about the horrors beyond the Wastes. Thankfully, I don't have to waste too much time on this stage of preparation; I already know next to everything that the Wastes has to offer. From the beautiful Alestrial Coral that lines the ground, to the crocodile-esque Thresher's, down to the drowned city of Celtor and its layout. However, it never hurts to brush up on any information I may have forgotten about.

Next up; equipment. If I'm going to perform at my best, I'm going to need top notch equipment of all varieties. Body armor, weapons, boots, everything. Problem is, I'll need to venture out of the Wastes to get the materials necessary for what I'm looking for, and I'll need permission from an expedition's supervisor to do so. So, I go and do just that.

I head to the expedition's room, taking in my surroundings. The room itself is lined with bookshelves, all of them neatly placed in alphabetical order. Dust floats around the dimly lit room, illuminated by a lamp on a stand right in the middle. The room seems unoccupied; I turn the knob to leave when-

"Hello; how may I help you?"

I nearly yell out a curse in shock; I turn towards the ceiling, where the

voice came from. Squinting, I try to make out the figure cloaked in the dark. Confusingly, I inquire:

"Uh, hello. Are you an expedition supervisor? I'm here to request permission to go on an expedition into the Wastes to procure some materials in preparation for the Citad-"

I stop midway; the figure drops from the ceiling, gracefully landing right in front me with a soft *thud*. By this point my eyes have finally adjusted to the lighting of the room, and I take in the figure staring right at me.

The man is clad in the Black Diver uniform, the light in the chest of the uniform glowing faintly. He has a toolbelt clad around his waist, and it has flasks haphazardly forced into its pockets. The flasks themselves are filled with liquids of various colors; just what would happen if they fell on the floor?

My eyes slowly trail upwards, until they rest on the face of the figure. Thin scars line the man's nose, almost mirrored. The man has eyes that swirl in endless circles, colored in green. Just above his eyebrows the man is wearing goggles. His hair is wild and unkempt, its color mirroring that of snow, a complete contrast to the man's skin tone; that of which is a dead ringer for the coal that lines the mines around Castle Light.

After realizing I'm staring, I quickly grow flustered and extend my hand for a handshake.

"Sorry for staring! My name is Arthur, Arthur Mirad. What's yours?"

It's while I'm introducing myself that I realize; this is my first time introducing myself with my new name. I've defined and humanized myself by taking on the name that was bestowed upon me; despite where it came from. I shudder to think of the implications of identifying myself with the name that an unknown…*entity* gave me. It feels weird.

The odd looking man slowly grins, taking my hand and shaking it.

"Heheheheheh! You may refer to me as Doctor Diver. *The* Doctor Diver. I'll spare the idle talk; what are you here for?"

I straighten my posture; this man is clearly intelligent and experienced. He bears the Black Diver uniform, a clear sign of aptitude and strength. Despite his…quirky way of speaking, I get the sense that he can see right through me, as if he saw things in a way nobody else could.

"I'm here to request an expedition into the Wastes, for the purpose of gathering materials and equipment that would benefit me in the Citadel Trials." I speak with confidence, trying to paint myself off as someone capable of venturing out into the Wastes and coming back alive.

The Doctor covers his mouth and gazes downward, beginning to shake. Confused and a little worried, I extend my hand in an attempt to reassure him. However, just as I'm about to grasp his shoulder, he throws his head back and cackles madly, droning on and on in a never-ending symphony of crazed laughter. I slowly walk backward, a little; no, very terrified. However, The Doctor suddenly stops laughing and peeks at me

through his splayed fingers, before lowering his hands entirely and pointing his finger dead at my chest.

"You, little Capra…you'll be granted permission to venture out into the Wastes, for whatever reasons you see fit. On one condition…"

The sudden shift in tone from crazed laughter to cohesive speech left my brain rattled and sluggish. There is something off about this man; being able to switch your demeanor so quickly like that, acting like nothing happened?

"…You travel alongside another Apprentice that I appoint. No arguing."

Huh?

I shake my head, running through those last couple of words. As I wrap my head around what he just said, he walks to the door and opens it outward, implying that I exit. As I leave the room, he speaks again.

"Don't pretend that you're a saint, Capra. I know what you are, and what consequences you could bring into this stronghold. Play for the other side, risking the lives of those under Castle Light's protection, and you will *sorely* regret it."

And then he promptly slams the door in my face.

Chapter 9: Icicle

I wake up the following day, checking it off on my calendar and getting out of bed. Feeling a little apprehensive about my expedition out into the Wastes later today, I absentmindedly pile on a mixture of urchin stew, glazed fish, and ongo on my plate, anxiously reviewing all of the weird events that began happening to me as of late.

Just what could The Doctor possibly have meant when he said, "the other side"? Why did he write me off as someone suspicious, someone dangerous enough to risk the lives of everyone in Castle Light? I've never come off as someone dangerous, have I? What did he mean when he said he knew what I was? Just what did he see in me that I couldn't see in myself?

As I run through the possibilities, another thought occurs to me; Klaris herself did the exact same thing, albeit to a smaller extent. The first time we interacted, she singled me out in a crowd of endless Apprentices. Just what do the Black Diver's know about me, and why are they keeping it a secret? Does it have something to do with the sinister statue that spoke to me?

I begin to think back on that night, when all of these weird occurrences began. Goosebumps ripple across my body as I recall the horrific *entity* that spoke to me. Try as I might, I couldn't forget what it said, the agonizing pain it inflicted upon me with every word it spoke. It takes a substantial amount of willpower, but I close my mind on those

thoughts, the questions it prompts, and the horror of it all. I've got other things to focus on right now; this can wait until later.

As I walk to the dining hall table to eat breakfast, it occurs to me that The Doctor never told me where and when I was supposed to meet the Apprentice accompanying me on our journey through the Wastes. Groaning inwardly, I decide to finish up breakfast and head out to the bridge separating the Wastes from Castle Light, betting on the Apprentice putting two and two together and meeting outside.

I reach the bridge, my gear jostling about. I run a quick check, just to be safe. Backpack? Check. Emergency supply of food and water? Check. A notebook to jot down any changes in the Wastes worth compiling? Check. Jellyfish glands to disguise our scent in the case of a monster attack? Check. A pickaxe to mine the ore surrounding the Wastes? Check.

Everything seems to be in place. Reaching into my pocket, I attempt to pull out the dagger I stashed away. Except…it's not there. I reach into my other pocket; nope, not there either. I check my back pockets; no dice. Confused, I'm about to unzip my backpack and rifle through it, when an unfamiliar voice drawls on from behind me.

"Are you looking for this?"

I turn around, a thank you playing on my lips, before stopping dead in my tracks and staring at the figure in front of me.

A Gremor stands before me, his skin a faint cloudy blue. His eyes are dark navy, reminiscent of Umbrite. His mouth is set in a tight line, clearly frowning. His hair is in a bun, with twin bangs mirroring the side of his head on the left and right side. He's juggling my missing dagger with one hand, clearly confident enough in his skills that he isn't worried about maiming himself accidentally. He comes off as confident, and haughty.

Hastily, I get up, brushing the dust off of my knees. I walk up to the Gremor and extend my hand for a handshake, plastering a friendly smile on my face. Yet, instead of taking the handshake, the Gremor instead smoothly places my missing dagger into my outstretched hand and walks past me, heading for the Wastes. A glint at his waist catches my eye; he bears a rapier on his waist.

Frowning a little, I catch up to him and stop him from moving any further with an outstretched arm. Slowly, the Gremor turns his head to look at me, his expression much colder than before, his already dark eyes somehow darkening further. Mustering up the resolve, I speak.

"Don't you think we should at least know each other's names before heading out into the unknown?"

A beat of silence. Then two.

And then the Gremor, with a single finger, pushes my outstretched arm down and continues walking towards the Wastes.

I run ahead and stop him again, a little frustrated now.

"Come on, at least tell me who you are. We can't exactly accomplish our goals out there if we can't work together, right?"

Another beat of silence. And then he speaks.

“My name is Gawain Nemira.”

And then he walks past the barrier, out into the darkness.

Chapter 10: Wastes

I run after Gawain, exiting the barrier separating Castle Light from the horrors of what lies beyond its protective stave. Immediately, I feel a chill enter my bones as the warmth that the barrier provided began to ebb and fade away. Scanning in front of me, I can just barely make Gawain out; he’s a couple yards out, nearly out of sight. Just how fast can this guy walk?

I sprint after him, gazing around the landscape spanning before me. It’s while I walk upon the moss covered soil that I realize something; the hills over the region, the light blue tint of baby Gigamed’s blanketing overhead, the faint sounds of the Megalodaunt; The Depths; no, *Scyphozia* houses many forms of life, despite it’s terrifying and dangerous environment. And yet, despite how treacherous it is to be here, monsters flourish. They grow, they adapt, they *evolve*. They form methods of communication, form families and share resources. Are we, those in Castle Light, truly in the right to be researching and excavating the resources here? Aren’t we intruding in their habitat, their homes? Can we really blame them for being so hostile towards us?

Mid-mulling, I noticed that Gawain finally stopped, turning towards me before impatiently tapping his foot on the ground, clearly signaling that I pick up the pace. I hurry over towards him, before reaching him slightly out of breath. He turns around and points towards an entrance to…something. Wherever it leads to, it’s so dark that I couldn’t make any guesses. Confused, I inquired over what he was pointing to.

“Uh, Gawain? What are you trying to show me, exactly?”

He paused, clearly trying to come up with an answer. Seemingly exasperated, he breathed a heavy sigh and explained:

“This isn’t the first expedition into the Wastes. I thought you’d have studied all the areas mapped out concerning The Depths by now, given your reputation.”

Uh, what reputation? Setting that aside, I *have* studied all the maps concerning the Wastes. All the safe routes, the excavation sites, anything published concerning The Depths; I know it all. I’d be surprised if there was any information that I didn’t know about, unless…

I turn towards Gawain, searching for any deceit or lies in his face. After a couple seconds of an intense staredown, his cold demeanor shifts ever so slightly, and he cracks a grin, throwing his hands up in a ‘you got me’ pose before speaking.

“Took you long enough. Yeah, this cave wasn’t mapped out, and that’s on purpose. The expedition team who uncovered it all swore to not tell a soul about it; the thing is, one of them’s a good friend of mine and told me

all about it, under the condition I never told anyone else. Clearly, I took that as a suggestion, not the rule. Anyway, apparently within that cave lies some serious treasure; loot and all that."

He starts up another sentence, before stopping at the sound of what appears to be..popping? We turn towards the sound, Gawain unsheathing his rapier in one smooth motion, clearly having experience with it. Fumbling through my pocket, I pull out my dagger in anticipation of an attack, ready for anything. The crackling sound of electricity gets closer and closer, until...

A singular blue Gigamed pops into view.

We slowly exchange a glance...before beginning to roll over on the ground laughing. Trying to stem the absurdity of our reactions towards a monster *this* unthreatening, we put away our weapons, regaining our composure.

That is, until a King Gigamed pops up right behind the singular blue Gigamed we just laughed at.

Our reactions are swift. We book it towards the cave, not hesitating for a second to consider combative options. As we sprint towards the darkened crevice, we hear the sounds of electricity building up. At first, it's slow. But as it builds up faster and faster, so does the pitch of the sound, growing more deafening and ear-grating. Gawain reaches the entrance of the cave first, summoning what appears to be Frostdraw as a foothold for me to get my balance. Just as the King Gigamed launches a string of lightning towards us, we make it into the cave, narrowly avoiding the blast. We're safe, for now.